CHINA'S BELT AND ROAD INITIATIVE AND GEORGIA'S ECONOMIC TRANSFORMATION AS A EURASIAN HUB

Maia Benia
PhD in Businesse Administration;
Georgian Technical University

Maia Gamsakhurdia
Ph.D. in International Relations;
David Aghmashenebeli National
Defence Academy of Georgia

Zurab Samkharadze
Ph.D. of Military Sciences
David Aghmashenebeli National
Defence Academy of Georgia

ABSTRACT

The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), launched by the People's Republic of China in 2013, has reconfigured the geo-economic landscape of Eurasia by promoting large-scale infrastructure, trade connectivity, and investment flows. Georgia, situated at the crossroads of Europe and Asia, has positioned itself as a strategic transit corridor and emerging logistics hub within this framework. This paper examines the transformative potential of the BRI for Georgia's economic development and regional role, emphasizing both historical precedents and future trajectories. The analysis highlights Georgia's evolving function as a bridge between European and Asian markets, focusing on infrastructural modernization, investment attraction, and institutional reforms. By embedding the Georgian case within broader Eurasian connectivity strategies, the study argues that Georgia's success as a hub depends on balancing external partnerships, internal competitiveness, and sustainable development priorities.

Keywords: Georgia;Middle Corridor;Belt and Road Initiative (BRI);Eurasian connectivity; East–West trade routes; U.S. strategic influence; EU Global Gateway; China's Belt and Road; Zangezur Corridor / Trump Route; Energy security; Black Sea submarine cable; Caspian–Black Sea integration; Transport and logistics hubs; Geopolitical competition; Regional cooperation (Kazakhstan, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Turkey); Institutional reforms; Investment security; Infrastructure modernization; Transit corridors; Small states and globalization.

ᲩᲘᲜᲔᲗᲘᲡ „ᲔᲠᲗᲘ ᲡᲐᲠᲢᲧᲚᲘᲡ ᲒᲖᲘᲡ“ ᲘᲜᲘᲪᲘᲐᲢᲘᲕᲐ ᲓᲐ ᲡᲐᲥᲐᲠᲗᲕᲔᲚᲝᲡ ᲔᲙᲝᲜᲝᲛᲘᲙᲣᲠᲘ ᲢᲠᲐᲜᲡᲤᲝᲠᲛᲐᲪᲘᲐ, ᲠᲝᲒᲝᲠᲪ ᲔᲕᲠᲐᲖᲘᲣᲚᲘ ᲪᲔᲜᲢᲠᲘ

ᲐᲑᲡᲢᲠᲐᲥᲢᲘ

„სარტყელისა და გზის ინიციატივამ“ (BRI), რომელიც ჩინეთის სახალხო რესპუბლიკამ 2013 წელს წამოიწყო, მნიშვნელოვნად გარდაქმნა ევრაზიის გეოეკონომიკური სივრცე, ხელი შეუწყო მასშტაბურ ინფრასტრუქტურულ პროექტებს, სავაჭრო დაკავშირებასა და საინვესტიციო ნაკადების ზრდას. საქართველო, როგორც ევროპისა და აზიის გზაჯვარედინზე მდებარე ქვეყანა, ამ ჩარჩოში პოზიციონირებს სტრატეგიულ სატრანზიტო დერეფნად და მზარდ ლოგისტიკურ ჰაბად. ნაშრომი იკვლევს BRI-ის გარდამტეხ პოტენციალს საქართველოს ეკონომიკური განვითარების და რეგიონული როლის კონტექსტში, ხაზს უსვამს როგორც ისტორიულ წინაპირობებს, ისე მომავალ პერსპექტივებს. ანალიზში განსაკუთრებული ყურადღება ეთმობა საქართველოს ევრო-აზიურ ბაზრებს შორის დამაკავშირებელ ფუნქციას, ინფრასტრუქტურული მოდერნიზაციის, ინვესტიციების მოზიდვისა და ინსტიტუციური რეფორმების თვალსაზრისით. ევრაზიული კავშირის უფრო ფართო სტრატეგიების ფონზე, კვლევა ასკვნის, რომ საქართველოს წარმატება როგორც რეგიონულ ჰაბად, დამოკიდებულია გარე პარტნიორობების დაბალანსებაზე, შიდა კონკურენტუნარიანობაზე და მდგრადი განვითარების პრიორიტეტებზე.

საკვანძო სიტყვები: სარტყელისა და გზის ინიციატივა (BRI), საქართველო, ევრაზიული კავშირი, სატრანზიტო დერეფანი, ლოგისტიკური ჰაბი, ინფრასტრუქტურული მოდერნიზაცია, საინვესტიციო პოტენციალი, ინსტიტუციური რეფორმები, ევროპა-აზიის დამაკავშირებელი ფუნქცია, მდგრადი განვითარება

INTRODUCTION

The transformation of the global economy in the 21st century is characterized by intensified connectivity across continents, reshaping not only trade flows but also the geostrategic relevance of transit states. The Belt and Road Initiative, with its ambition to link Asia, Europe, and Africa through infrastructure, energy, and digital corridors, provides unprecedented opportunities for small states with advantageous geographic locations. Georgia exemplifies such a case. Historically located at the intersection of the Silk Road routes, the country has long served as a passageway for goods, cultures, and empires. Today, Georgia's government and business community seek to reposition the country as a Eurasian hub by leveraging its strategic geography, modernized transport infrastructure, and integration with European and trans-Caspian networks.

Georgia's role in the Belt and Road Initiative demonstrates how a small state can transform structural vulnerabilities into competitive advantages by acting as a Eurasian bridge. This transformation, however, requires a multidimensional strategy:

Historical Continuity – revitalizing the Silk Road legacy to enhance cultural legitimacy and global branding;

Economic Modernization – developing logistics corridors, ports, and railways to support East–West trade;

Institutional Reforms – ensuring transparency, regulatory alignment with EU standards, and investment security;

Strategic Balancing – managing relations with China, the European Union, and regional powers while preserving sovereignty and policy autonomy.

By pursuing these strategic dimensions, Georgia can harness the BRI not merely as a transit channel but as a catalyst for long-term economic transformation.

GEORGIA AS A BRIDGE BETWEEN EUROPE AND ASIA: HISTORICAL PARADIGM AND NEW VISION

Historically, Georgia's role as a connector between empires was defined by its position along the Silk Road, which facilitated exchanges of silk, wine, metalwork, and ideas. Its ports on the Black Sea and mountain passes through the Caucasus provided indispensable routes for merchants traveling from China to the Mediterranean. This historical paradigm created both opportunities and vulnerabilities: prosperity during periods of stable connectivity, and disruption during eras of geopolitical fragmentation.

In the contemporary era, Georgia seeks to reinterpret this legacy under the Belt and Road Initiative. The Anaklia Deep Sea Port, the Baku–Tbilisi–Kars (BTK) railway, and the modernization of the East–West highway represent efforts to position the country as the shortest and most secure land corridor linking China with European markets. Moreover, Georgia's Association Agreement and Deep and Comprehensive Free Trade Area (DCFTA) with the European Union provide an institutional framework that differentiates it from other BRI transit states. This dual alignment – physical connectivity with China and regulatory alignment with Europe – constitutes Georgia's unique strategic advantage.

The new vision of Georgia as a Eurasian hub extends beyond transit. It includes ambitions to attract logistics services, digital trade platforms, financial centers, and regional headquarters for multinational firms. Success in this endeavor depends on strengthening governance, ensuring environmental sustainability in infrastructure projects, and fostering human capital capable of servicing an interconnected Eurasian economy.

Economic Modernization: Corridors, Ports, and Railways as the Backbone of Georgia's Eurasian Transformation

Economic modernization constitutes the foundation of Georgia's strategic vision to evolve from a transit corridor into a competitive Eurasian hub. The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) provides not only an external framework but also financing and strategic incentives to accelerate the development of transport, logistics, and energy infrastructures. For Georgia, the focus lies on three interdependent pillars: logistics corridors, ports, and railways.

Logistics Corridors and Multimodal Integration - Georgia's East–West Highway, part of the TRACECA (Transport Corridor Europe–Caucasus–Asia) framework, remains the central artery enabling efficient movement of goods across the Caucasus. Ongoing projects supported by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) and World Bank aim to bring the highway in line with international standards, reducing travel times between the Black Sea ports and the Azerbaijani border. When integrated with digital logistics platforms and customs modernization, such corridors can decrease transaction costs and enhance Georgia's attractiveness as a transit state.

Moreover, the country's strategic role in the Middle Corridor—the Trans-Caspian International Transport Route (TITR)—has grown in significance following disruptions in traditional northern routes due to the Russia–Ukraine war. The Middle Corridor connects China to Europe via Kazakhstan, the Caspian Sea, Azerbaijan, Georgia, and Turkey, bypassing Russia. Georgia's modernization of border checkpoints, digitalization of customs procedures, and investment in dry ports are critical to reducing bottlenecks and ensuring competitiveness relative to northern and southern routes.

Port Development and Maritime Connectivity - Maritime gateways are indispensable to Georgia's hub strategy. The ports of Poti and Batumi serve as traditional access points to the Black Sea, facilitating trade with European markets. However, their limited depth restricts capacity for larger Panamax and post-Panamax vessels. The planned Anaklia Deep Sea Port project represents a transformative venture, intended to handle up to 100 million tons of cargo annually and accommodate the largest container ships. Anaklia's strategic vision is not limited to transshipment; it also envisages a free industrial zone to attract logistics, manufacturing, and value-added services. If realized, Anaklia could alter regional trade patterns by positioning Georgia as the primary maritime gateway for Central Asia and Western China.

Railway Networks and Eurasian Integration - Rail infrastructure complements maritime and highway development by enabling cost-effective and environmentally sustainable freight transport. The Baku–Tbilisi–Kars (BTK) railway, inaugurated in 2017, connects the Caspian region directly to Turkey and onward to European rail systems. For Georgia, BTK is not merely a transport link but also an instrument of strategic diversification, reducing dependence on Russian transit routes. Modernization of the Georgian Railway—including electrification, signaling upgrades, and capacity expansion in mountainous areas—will be essential to handle projected cargo growth under the BRI framework.

Simultaneously, Georgia's integration into the EU Trans-European Transport Network (TEN-T) provides an institutional and regulatory complement to physical modernization. Harmonization of safety standards, interoperability, and customs procedures ensures that Georgia's rail infrastructure is embedded within a broader European economic space.

Beyond Transit: Toward Logistics Clusters -Infrastructure investments gain long-term economic value only when embedded into logistics clusters that generate spillover effects in employment, technology transfer, and industrial development. Georgia's free industrial zones in Poti, Kutaisi, and Tbilisi, combined with customs reforms and simplified tax regimes, offer fertile ground for such clusters. If connected effectively to BRI corridors, these zones could host warehousing, light manufacturing, and digital trade platforms, shifting Georgia's role from "corridor" to "connector" in the global economy. Economic modernization through corridors, ports, and railways is not merely a technical exercise in infrastructure but a strategic choice that redefines Georgia's global position. By aligning physical modernization with digital platforms, EU regulatory frameworks, and sustainable investment standards, Georgia can transform into a genuine Eurasian hub—leveraging geography not as vulnerability, but as a source of competitive advantage.

Institutional Reforms: Transparency, EU Regulatory Alignment, and Investment Security - While geography and infrastructure provide Georgia with the physical foundation for becoming a Eurasian hub, it is institutional reforms that ultimately determine the credibility and sustainability of this ambition. The country's ability to attract foreign direct investment (FDI), integrate into global value chains, and serve as a secure bridge between Europe and Asia depends heavily on the quality of governance, regulatory frameworks, and investor protections.

Transparency and Governance - One of Georgia's distinguishing features in the post-Soviet space has been its rapid progress in anti-corruption reforms. Since the early 2000s, Georgia has moved from being perceived as a highly corrupt state to a recognized reform leader, reflected in indices such as Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index. Simplified licensing regimes, digitalization of public services, and the elimination of petty bribery have strengthened trust in institutions.

However, transparency challenges remain. Large-scale infrastructure projects under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)—including port and railway development—risk exposure to opaque procurement practices and politically influenced decision-making. To sustain credibility with international investors, Georgia must ensure that contracts, bidding processes, and public-private partnerships (PPPs) remain open to scrutiny, with robust parliamentary and civil society oversight.

Regulatory Alignment with EU Standards - The EU–Georgia Association Agreement (2014) and the Deep and Comprehensive Free Trade Area (DCFTA) provide Georgia with a unique advantage among BRI transit states. Unlike many regional competitors, Georgia is progressively aligning its trade, customs, and regulatory standards with the European Union. This alignment offers two strategic benefits:

Predictability for Investors: EU-aligned regulations reduce uncertainty for foreign firms by harmonizing technical standards, intellectual property protections, and dispute settlement mechanisms.

Market Access: By adhering to EU sanitary, phytosanitary, and product standards, Georgian producers gain tariff-free access to the world's largest single market. For infrastructure specifically, EU alignment ensures compliance with Trans-European Transport Network (TEN-T) standards, facilitating interoperability with European logistics systems. In practice, this means adopting EU rules on railway safety, customs facilitation, and digital transport systems—critical for Georgia's role as a reliable corridor for East–West trade.

Investment Security and Legal Frameworks - Foreign investors in large-scale transport and logistics infrastructure demand not only physical connectivity but also legal security. Georgia has made progress by adopting investor-friendly tax regimes (e.g., low corporate tax rates, free industrial zones, and simplified customs procedures). It is also a member of the World

Trade Organization (WTO) and a signatory to multiple bilateral investment treaties, providing legal recourse for dispute settlement.

Nevertheless, risks persist. The suspension of the Anaklia Deep Sea Port project in 2020 raised questions about government commitment and investor security, highlighting the need for stronger guarantees of contract enforcement and depoliticization of strategic projects. Strengthening the independence of the judiciary and reinforcing arbitration mechanisms will be key to attracting long-term BRI-related investments.

Balancing External Pressures - Institutional reforms also have a geopolitical dimension. As Georgia deepens its alignment with EU standards while engaging with Chinese-led BRI projects, it must balance competing regulatory environments. China's investment approach is often characterized by flexibility and state-to-state agreements, whereas the EU emphasizes rule-based governance and environmental safeguards. Georgia's institutional resilience will be tested in its ability to harmonize these approaches without undermining either credibility with European partners or investment opportunities from China.

Digital Governance and Smart Regulation - Looking forward, institutional reforms should expand beyond traditional transparency and legal frameworks to embrace digital governance. Georgia has already made strides in e-governance, including online business registration, e-tax systems, and blockchain-based land registries. Integrating such technologies into customs clearance, trade facilitation, and logistics operations could reduce transaction costs, combat corruption, and signal to global partners that Georgia is not only a geographic bridge but also an institutional innovator.

Institutional reforms form the software of Georgia's economic modernization strategy. While physical infrastructure connects regions, it is transparency, EU-aligned regulatory standards, and robust investor protections that provide the confidence necessary for long-term growth. By sustaining anti-corruption reforms, strengthening judicial independence, harmonizing EU and BRI standards, and leveraging digital governance, Georgia can position itself as a credible, rules-based hub linking Europe and Asia.

WORLD BANK'S SUPPORT FOR AZERBAIJAN'S MIDDLE CORRIDOR AND IMPLICATIONS FOR GEORGIA

On September 22, 2025, at the First Azerbaijan International Investment Forum in Baku, Rolande Pryce, the World Bank Regional Director for the South Caucasus, reiterated the Bank's strong support for Azerbaijan's initiatives regarding the Middle Corridor. This trans-Caspian route, connecting Asia with Europe through Central Asia, the Caspian Sea, Azerbaijan, Georgia, and Turkey, is increasingly viewed as a strategic alternative to traditional northern routes disrupted by geopolitical tensions.

Key Elements of the World Bank's Support - Middle Corridor Infrastructure – The World Bank emphasized its commitment to transport connectivity projects that strengthen East–West flows, reduce logistics costs, and enhance regional integration. Energy Transmission Projects – The Bank is backing the development of a power line running under the Caspian and Black Seas. This infrastructure will allow the export of renewable energy generated in Central Asia and Azerbaijan to European markets.

Technological Spillovers – According to Pryce, electricity exports will encourage the parallel growth of information technologies, positioning the South Caucasus as not only a transit hub but also an innovation platform.

European Energy Security – The diversification of supply chains and renewable energy exports contributes directly to the EU's energy security agenda, particularly amid efforts to reduce reliance on Russian resources.

Implications for Georgia - Georgia, as a central node along the Middle Corridor, stands to gain significantly from these initiatives:

Strengthening Transit Competitiveness - The Middle Corridor's effectiveness depends on seamless integration across Azerbaijan and Georgia. Investments in Azerbaijani infrastructure, supported by the World Bank, create momentum that extends naturally to Georgia's East–West Highway, the Baku–Tbilisi–Kars railway, and Black Sea ports.

Georgia's role as the "land bridge" to Turkey and the EU makes it indispensable to the corridor's efficiency. Enhanced infrastructure in Azerbaijan raises the urgency for **Georgia** to accelerate its own modernization projects (e.g., Anaklia Deep Sea Port, rail upgrades, customs digitalization).

Energy Transmission and Regional Integration - The planned undersea power lines across the Caspian and Black Seas have direct consequences for Georgia's energy sector. The Black Sea cable project, previously backed by the EU, envisions Georgia as the gateway for green electricity exports from Azerbaijan and Central Asia to Europe.

For Georgia, this implies investment inflows into its transmission grid, potential revenues from transit fees, and opportunities to expand domestic renewable generation that could be fed into the same networks.

Technological and Digital Opportunities - As electricity export projects stimulate the development of ICT sectors in Azerbaijan and Central Asia, Georgia can position itself as the regional digital hub. Existing initiatives such as Tbilisi's free industrial zones, ICT parks, and e-governance reforms create a favorable ecosystem for digital spillovers associated with energy infrastructure. Enhanced regional interconnectivity opens the door to cross-border fintech, logistics data management, and smart-grid solutions, areas where Georgia already has a reform-driven comparative advantage.

Strategic and Geopolitical Leverage - Georgia's alignment with both the EU (through the Association Agreement and DCFTA) and the Middle Corridor strengthens its bargaining position in Eurasian geopolitics. By participating in World Bank–backed projects that serve both European and Asian markets, Georgia can reinforce its dual identity as both an Eastern Partnership country and a Silk Road connector.

The World Bank's endorsement of Azerbaijan's Middle Corridor initiatives creates a positive ripple effect across the South Caucasus. For Georgia, the stakes are particularly high: enhanced infrastructure integration, access to renewable energy trade routes, and opportunities for digital economy growth. Yet, capitalizing on these opportunities requires parallel institutional reforms, sustainable investment strategies, and acceleration of stalled megaprojects. If Georgia succeeds, it will consolidate its role not merely as a passageway but as a strategic Eurasian hub where energy, trade, and digital innovation converge.

WORLD BANK'S SUPPORT FOR AZERBAIJAN'S MIDDLE CORRIDOR AND IMPLICATIONS FOR GEORGIA

On September 22, 2025, at the First Azerbaijan International Investment Forum in Baku, Rolande Pryce, the World Bank Regional Director for the South Caucasus, reiterated the Bank's strong support for Azerbaijan's initiatives regarding the Middle Corridor. This trans-Caspian route, connecting Asia with Europe through Central Asia, the Caspian Sea, Azerbaijan, Georgia, and Turkey, is increasingly viewed as a strategic alternative to traditional northern routes disrupted by geopolitical tensions.

Middle Corridor Infrastructure – The World Bank emphasized its commitment to transport connectivity projects that strengthen East–West flows, reduce logistics costs, and enhance regional integration. Energy Transmission Projects – The Bank is backing the development of a power line running under the Caspian and Black Seas. This infrastructure will allow the export of renewable energy generated in Central Asia and Azerbaijan to European markets.

Technological Spillovers – According to Pryce, electricity exports will encourage the parallel growth of information technologies, positioning the South Caucasus as not only a transit hub but also an innovation platform. European Energy Security – The diversification of supply chains and renewable energy exports contributes directly to the EU's energy security agenda, particularly amid efforts to reduce reliance on Russian resources.

The World Bank's endorsement of Azerbaijan's Middle Corridor initiatives creates a positive ripple effect across the South Caucasus. For Georgia, the stakes are particularly high: enhanced infrastructure integration, access to renewable energy trade routes, and opportunities for digital economy growth. Yet, capitalizing on these opportunities requires parallel institutional reforms, sustainable investment strategies, and acceleration of stalled megaprojects. If Georgia succeeds, it will consolidate its role not merely as a passageway but as a strategic Eurasian hub where energy, trade, and digital innovation converge.

The unfolding dynamics of the Middle Corridor underscore how infrastructure projects in Eurasia are no longer neutral economic ventures but deeply political instruments of power. The so-called "Trump Route" through southern Armenia epitomizes this trend: a corridor marketed as peacebuilding, yet in practice functioning as a strategic lease that entrenches U.S. influence, provokes Iranian and Russian resistance, and intensifies global competition with China and the EU.

The reason for this heightened contest is clear: Eurasian connectivity is no longer only about trade efficiency, but about control over choke points, diversification of energy and logistics supply chains, and the projection of strategic sovereignty. With the northern routes weakened by war and sanctions, every alternative corridor has become a battleground for multipolar competition.

For Georgia, the impact is profound and twofold. On the one hand, increased U.S., EU, and Chinese engagement with the Middle Corridor amplifies Georgia's value as a secure land bridge between the Caspian and the Black Sea. Foreign investment in ports, railways, and digital customs systems could strengthen its role as the indispensable transit node linking Azerbaijan and Turkey with European markets. On the other hand, the overlapping sovereignties and rivalries surrounding the corridor heighten Georgia's exposure to external pressure and regional volatility. Any instability in Armenia, Iran's opposition, or Russia's countermoves could spill over into Georgia's security and economic landscape.

Ultimately, Georgia's challenge will be to convert its geographic advantage into institutional credibility and strategic balance. By maintaining strong EU alignment, ensuring transparent governance, and cultivating balanced partnerships with both China and the United States, Georgia can position itself not as a passive transit route but as an active shaper of the Middle Corridor's future. The country's fate in this new geopolitical chessboard will hinge less on the ambitions of great powers and more on its ability to leverage external competition into sustainable growth, energy diversification, and deeper integration with Europe.

POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS FOR GEORGIA

Accelerate Infrastructure Modernization – Prioritize the completion of the Anaklia Deep Sea Port, East–West Highway upgrades, and railway modernization to ensure competitiveness within the Middle Corridor.

Strengthen Institutional Credibility – Deepen anti-corruption reforms, ensure transparent procurement, and align fully with EU regulatory standards to attract and safeguard foreign investment.

Balance External Partnerships – Maintain a careful equilibrium between U.S., EU, and Chinese involvement, avoiding overdependence on any single actor while leveraging competition to secure better financing and technology.

Enhance Energy and Digital Integration – Maximize benefits from the Black Sea electricity cable project by expanding renewable energy exports and positioning Georgia as a digital logistics hub.

Promote Regional Cooperation – Work closely with Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, and Turkey to harmonize customs, logistics, and security policies, ensuring the corridor's reliability against external disruptions.

For Georgia, the Middle Corridor is both an opportunity and a test. It offers the chance to transform from a vulnerable small state into a strategic Eurasian hub linking Europe and Asia. Yet this transformation requires more than geography; it demands credible institutions, sustainable infrastructure, and smart diplomacy. By aligning with EU standards while engaging constructively with China and the U.S., Georgia can turn external rivalries into engines of growth—securing its long-term role as a resilient and indispensable bridge across Eurasia.

REFERENCES:

1. **Asian Development Bank.** (2021). *Georgia: East–West Highway Corridor Improvement Project.* Manila: Asian Development Bank. https://www.adb.org/projects/49257-001/main

2. **AZERTAC.** (2025, September 22). *World Bank supports Azerbaijan's initiatives on Middle Corridor, says regional director Rolande Pryce.* https://azertag.az/en/xeber/world_bank_supports_azerbaijan_039s_initiatives_on_middle_corridor_says_regional_director-3758499

3. **Babones, S.** (2017). *American Tianxia: Chinese Money, American Power, and the End of History.* Bristol: Policy Press. https://policy.bristoluniversitypress.co.uk/american-tianxia

4. **Beeson, M.** (2018). Geoeconomics with Chinese characteristics: The BRI and China's evolving grand strategy. *Economic and Political Studies, 6*(3), 240–256. https://doi.org/10.1080/20954816.2018.1498988

5. **Caucasus Analytical Digest.** (2023). *The Middle Corridor and South Caucasus Connectivity* (No. 126, pp. 1–10). Caucasus Analytical Digest. https://css.ethz.ch/en/publications/cad.html

6. **Eurasia Review.** (2025, September 24). *Who owns the Middle Corridor Agency and rivalry in Eurasia?* https://www.eurasiareview.com/24092025-who-owns-the-middle-corridor-agency-and-rivalry-in-eurasia-analysis/

7. **European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD).** (2020). *Transition report 2020–21: The state strikes back.* London: European Bank for Reconstruction and Development. https://www.ebrd.com/home/news-and-events/publications/economics/transition-reports/transition-report-2020-21.html

8. **European Commission.** (2014). *Association Agreement between the European Union and Georgia.* Brussels: European Union. https://eur-lex.europa.eu/eli/agree_internation/2014/494/oj/eng

9. **Friedrich Ebert Stiftung (FES) Georgia.** (2025). *The Perspectives of the Middle Corridor in an Age of Geopolitical Turbulence.* Tbilisi: Friedrich Ebert Stiftung. https://library.fes.de/pdf-files/bueros/georgien/22254-20250728.pdf

10. **Gabusi, G.** (2017). 'Crossing the River by Feeling the Gold': The Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank and the financial support to the Belt and Road Initiative. *Institutions & Transition Economics: Microeconomic Issues eJournal.* https://doi.org/10.1111/cwe.12212

11. **Gu, A., & Zhou, X.** (2020). Emission reduction effects of green energy investment projects of China in Belt and Road Initiative countries. *Ecosystem Health and Sustainability, 6*(1). https://doi.org/10.1080/20964129.2020.1747947

12. **International Monetary Fund (IMF).** (2021). *Georgia: 2021 Article IV Consultation, Staff Report (IMF Country Report No. 21/215).* Washington, DC: International Monetary Fund. https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/CR/Issues/2021/07/28/Georgia-2021-Article-IV-Consultation-Staff-Report-462982

13. **Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD).** (2023). *Realising the potential of the Middle Corridor for Eurasian connectivity.* Paris: OECD Publishing. https://www.oecd.org/en/publications/realising-the-potential-of-the-middle-corridor_635ad854-en.html

14. Sutherland, D., Anderson, J., Bailey, N., & Alon, I. (2020). Policy, institutional fragility, and Chinese outward foreign direct investment: An empirical examination of the Belt and Road Initiative. *Journal of International Business Policy,* 1–24. https://doi.org/10.1057/s42214-020-00056-8

15. Transparency International. (2022). *Corruption Perceptions Index 2022.* Berlin: Transparency International. https://www.transparency.org/en/cpi/2022

16. Wei, H., Sheng, Z., & Lee, P. (2018). The role of dry ports in hub-and-spoke networks under the Belt and Road Initiative. *Maritime Policy & Management, 45*(3), 370–387. https://doi.org/10.1080/03088839.2017.1396505

17. World Bank. (2020). *Doing Business 2020: Georgia.* Washington, DC: World Bank. https://archive.doingbusiness.org/en/data/exploreeconomies/georgia

18. World Bank. (2022). *Performance and Learning Review for the Country Partnership Framework for Georgia FY19–FY22.* Washington, DC: World Bank. https://documents.worldbank.org/en/publication/documents-reports/documentdetail/099120723121530037

19. World Bank. (2023). *Logistics Performance Index 2023: Connecting to Compete.* Washington, DC: World Bank. https://lpi.worldbank.org

20. Yang, G., Huang, X., Huang, J., & Chen, H. (2020). Assessment of the effects of infrastructure investment under the Belt and Road Initiative. *China Economic Review, 60,* 101418. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chieco.2020.101418

21. Yu, H. (2017). Motivation behind China's 'One Belt, One Road' Initiatives and establishment of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank. *Journal of Contemporary China, 26*(105), 353–368. https://doi.org/10.1080/10670564.2016.1245894

22. Ziyadov, T. (2012). *Azerbaijan as a Regional Hub in Central Eurasia: Strategic Policy Choices for Azerbaijan.* Baku: ADA University Press. https://www.ada.edu.az/file_upload/publications/other7.pdf